

A Novell Spree

Novell has announced that it is taking over one of the leading Linux companies—SuSE. Novell will pay \$210 million in cash; the acquisition is expected to be completed by January 2004. In August 2003, Novell acquired Ximian, another Linux-based company. Acquiring SuSE will allow Novell to offer complete Linux solutions, from desktops to enterprises. Such a deal will make Novell a serious player in the Linux market.

However, SCO, a Unix-based company, claims that it inherited a non-compete agreement from Santa Cruz Operations when it bought the latter's Unix business in 2000. This agreement prevents Novell from competing with SCO; by distributing Linux, Novell would be competing with SCO.

SCO has also hinted at taking the copyright infringement fight beyond Linux; it's now looking at Berkeley Software Distribution (BSD)-based OSes such as FreeBSD, OpenBSD, NetBSD, and possibly Apple.

snapshot

MSN reports profits for the first time in 8 years

Source: Yahoo!

The great Xbox shuffle

Control over hardware is key to the success of a gaming console unit. So, Sony uses made-to-order chips from IBM, ditto Nintendo.

How does this afford control? Take the Xbox as an example. By using an Intel Pentium 3 processor as the heart of its system, the console is only a few hacks away from becoming a low-cost PC.

There's another reason—piracy. Piracy is rampant on the DVD-based Xbox system. A console draws revenue by selling games, and piracy quickly becomes a

major headache.

To tackle these issues, Microsoft recently made several announcements. Two major contributors to the Xbox are out of the game:

Intel and nVidia.

Microsoft has recently signed a technology deal with IBM that will power future Xbox products.

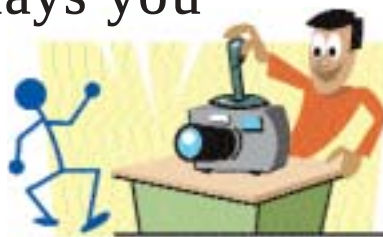
Microsoft also announced that SiS will supply the chipset technology for the future console. Finally, to replace the nVidia graphical powerhouse of the current Xbox, Microsoft has signed on ATI—nVidia's arch-rival.



EyeToy plays you

What started as an underwater camera meant for automated surveillance of marine life is now visiting the largest selling gaming console—the Sony PS2. The EyeToy is a PS2 peripheral that jacks into the unit's USB port. Richard Marks, a 34-year astronautical and aeronautical engineer, was the brains behind it.

The camera gained popularity because it is able to track movements of players and translate those into the game being played. This flattens the



learning curve involved.

EyeToy's technology was originally developed for more dangerous missions—the video sensors can be used to track schools of jellyfish, perform outer-space repair jobs, and to clean up nuclear waste. Sony's Vaio laptop division has already expressed interest in the prototype.

heroes

System Emulators

Microsoft and Intel—the pioneers of the Wintel platform—are working on system emulators. Intel plans to provide support for virtualisation at the hardware level with its Vanderpool technology.

Online Music stores

Following the success of Apple iTunes, almost all the top-tier companies such as Dell, Sony, Real Networks, etc., are starting online music stores. Microsoft has announced plans to launch one next year.

zeroes

Electronic Bugs in Cars

Bugs in computer controls are causing luxury cars such as the BMW 7 series, Mercedes-Benz S-Class and E-Class to behave in a weird manner. CDs spit out at passengers, the fuel gauge shows a faulty reading, and at times the engine switches off on the highway!

Red Hat Desktop Linux

Red Hat will drop all support for desktop Linux from April 2004, retaining it only for the Enterprise Edition. Red Hat has also started Fedora—a community project through which it provides free products, sans any support.



■ Kasparov draws with the X3D Fritz computer. The match was played on a virtual floating chess board ■ HP plans to enter the television market

Mr. Santa Claus

Think beyond Red and White.

Microsoft